

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap
A data-driven overview of global mental health conditions, 2023

SOURCE: OUR WORLD IN DATA · IHME GLOBAL BURDEN OF DISEASE (2025)

Hundreds of Millions Affected



1 in 3

Women will experience major depression in their lifetime

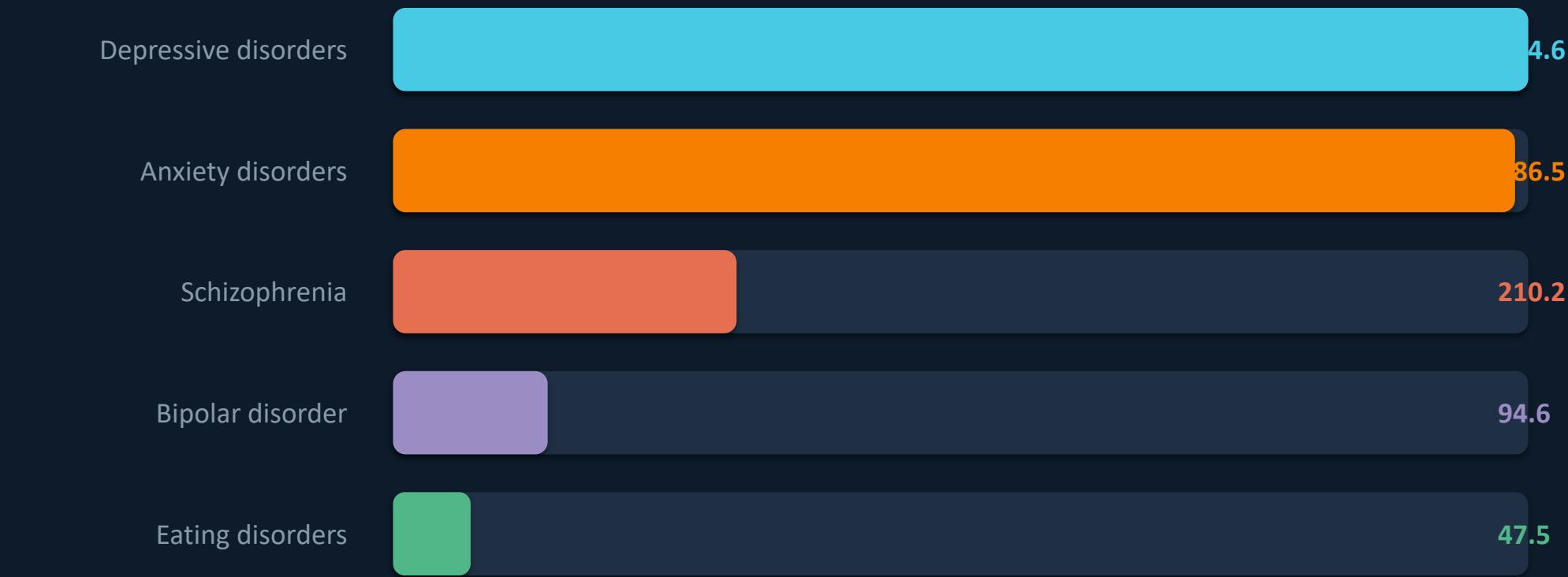


1 in 5

Men will experience major depression in their lifetime

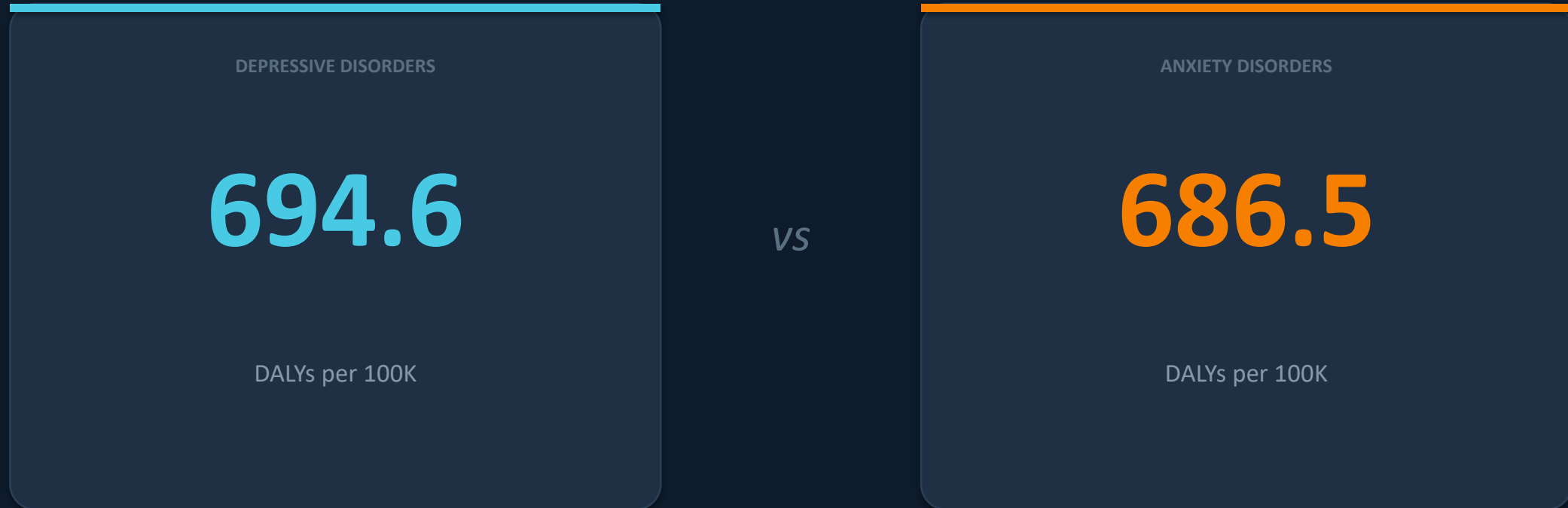
Other conditions such as schizophrenia and bipolar disorder are less common but have a large impact on individuals' lives. Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate the Global Burden



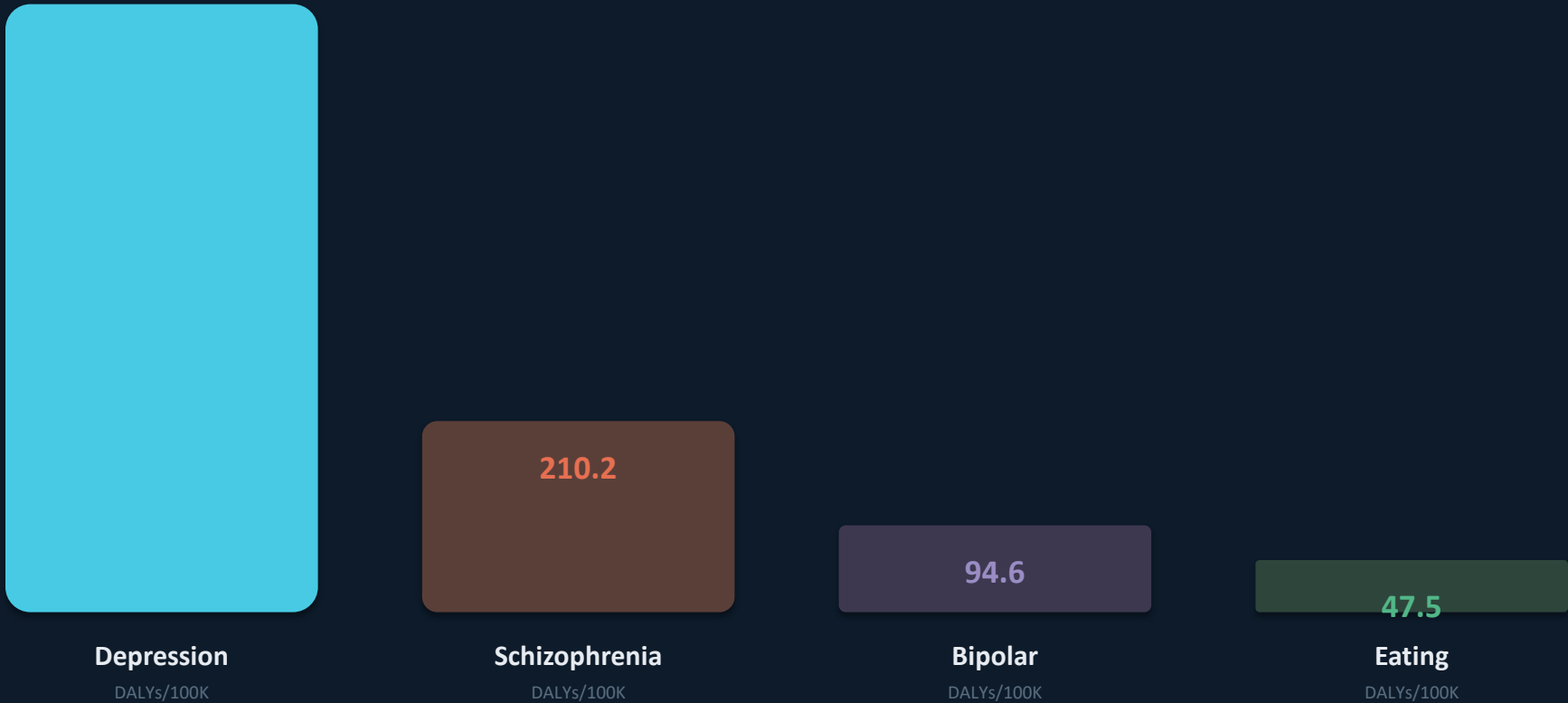
DALYs per 100,000 people · World, 2023 · Source: IHME Global Burden of Disease

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Burden



Together, depression and anxiety account for roughly 80% of the total mental health disease burden across these five categories — dwarfing all other conditions combined.

Lower Prevalence, Severe Individual Impact



Schizophrenia carries a disproportionately high individual burden relative to its prevalence, contributing 210.2 DALYs per 100,000 — reflecting the severe disability associated with the condition.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking



Stigma

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or even to people they know.



Access

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.



Quality

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality.



Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate the true prevalence — actual burden may be higher.

Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced — yet the treatment gap persists worldwide.

How People Cope Across the World



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings with established healthcare systems



Spiritual & Religious Practices

Prevalent in many regions worldwide, reflecting deep cultural traditions



Talking to Friends & Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across countries and cultures

The diversity of coping strategies underscores that mental health responses are shaped by cultural, economic, and healthcare system factors. Policy must account for these differences rather than applying a one-size-fits-all approach.

Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

- 1** Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs — each generating ~690 DALYs per 100K.
- 2** Schizophrenia and bipolar carry disproportionate individual burden relative to their prevalence.
- 3** Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate — the treatment gap is a global failure.
- 4** Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data — the true burden is likely underestimated.
- 5** Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.